



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 10

FLORIDA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Florida's family courts and child-welfare system.

115

FLORIDA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 112
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 30 MONTHS
MEDIAN TIME IN SYSTEM

REPORT GENERATED

APRIL 20, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

10 OF 67

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

FLORIDA AT A GLANCE.

Across 115 Florida families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 112 48 of 115 families reporting with kids	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$25,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 30 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 55.7% 27.0% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 115	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 2.3	REPORTING FAMILIES 48 of 115	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 10

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Florida families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF FLORIDA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	67	\$25,000	\$57,098	\$3,825,570
Lost Wages	53	\$24,000	\$370,636	\$19,643,700
Other Court Fees	39	\$1,000	\$4,529	\$176,645
Therapy / Evaluations	54	\$1,925	\$8,427	\$455,070
Reunification Services	40	\$400	\$3,697	\$147,885
GAL Fees	43	\$1,000	\$17,441	\$749,965
Asset Loss ¹	54	\$54,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$107,325	—	—

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$54,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		30	2.5 yrs
Mean months lost		40	3.3 yrs
Total across all families		2,200	183.3 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · FLORIDA

Most families documenting in Florida are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Currently involved / "S...		37	32%
Case closed (within th...		10	9%
Case closed (more tha...		9	8%
I am currently stuck in ...		4	3%
I am not currently in co...		1	1%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and ...		45	39%
Family Court Only		21	18%
CPS (Child Protective ...		15	13%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		22	19%
3 – 5 years		19	17%
5 – 10 years		18	16%
5+ years		15	13%
1-3 years		9	8%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Los...		41	36%
50/50 Joint		16	14%
Visitation Only		15	13%
Adopted Out (Rights T...		14	12%
Full Custody		9	8%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Polk		5	4%
Pinellas		4	3%
Lee		3	3%
Okaloosa		3	3%
Volusia		3	3%
Pasco		3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Acc...		22	19%
False Accusations CPS...		18	16%
Other: (Short answer)		15	13%
Family Court		14	12%
High Conflict Divorce		8	7%

05 PARENT VOICES — FLORIDA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Ruined all of us I suffer from PTSD trauma, anxiety, torture, because I think about my daughters every day they're being well taken care of my family is extremely disappointed. My mother passed away, never met my daughters and her final words were for me to do whatever it takes [...]

— BRUNA

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

I already put before, but violated due process caused harm to the children, confusion, took time away made the children believe they were liars and confused them of what truth is and enabled financial and mental and emotional abuse of myself and the kids to continue and extreme [...]

— FLORIDA PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM FLORIDA

Left me broken inside, being a mom is my greatest blessing and my kids were stolen from me without even asking me what happened or hearing me at all.

— CHASTITY

This has destroyed my children - A+ students down to Fs and suspensions from school, mental issues and suicidal thoughts, major health issues with their father denying anything being wrong with them, kids surviving regular abuse while their father hides behind "corporal [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Traumatized my children (and the parents), caused punitive damages, emotional harm, financial issues, etc

— MELISSA

Tore us apart and broke many bonds #KaynTay Pamela Bokhoven #KaynTay Shop and Outreach Campaign Manager, aoa-anc.org Justice and Accountability Act Committee written by Francesca Amato Francesca Amato 325-225-8050 Subject: Urgent Call for Family Justice and Accountability Reform [...]

— PAM

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Family court is a broken system, attorneys all say they same they want to help they care, bullshit they just want money. You can have proof but once your in the system there is no way of getting out. You are stuck spending money and have to sit and watch your children suffer. [...]

— VANESSA

Systematic psychological abuse, finacial abuse, civil rights violations, parental rights violations, ferpa violations

— DUSTIN

Family court consistently leaned into parental rights over children's rights leaving them 50% of the time with an unsafe documented abuser and alcoholic.

— SAMANTHA

It has broken my trust in support for woman and children such as myself and my daughter, it has caused me severe depression, it has gotten me ill, caused strife in my family, has caused financial hardship and my daughter has been handed to an abuser to be traumatized and [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Because of this system I have no family, and my children are missing a vital part of theirs.

— DANIELLE

The system has caused significant distress to our family, impacting our children and traumatizing my wife and me, as well as our five children. We are seeking justice and accountability for these actions.

— PAUL

Stolen parts of me that I'll ever get back. I'm mourning people that are still alive and I hold it together every day for the sake of myself and my other two kids

— BROOKE

Split the family up adopted to strangers when siblings and other relatives were available to care for children

— BRENDA

Harm, PTSD, damages, lost of all my kids young moment. Puberty, teen time completely loss.

— NYULKA

Completely stripped me of my autonomy safety, and entire sense of self

— CHRISTINA

A controlling father and his family made multiple false claims with CPS until they found an investigator who falsified reports in order to remove the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



When they walked into my life this last time I had Recently married my boyfriend from when I was 16 years old, we had three kids. We lived across the street from his parents. We had a new pick up truck . We needed help with housing upgrades and communication and some other [...]

— THYME

They destroyed my life and my family and my life

— STEPHANIE

This system didn't protect our family—it destroyed it. My brother's three children were taken in the middle of the night and split apart into different homes, stripping them not only from their father but from each other. Siblings who were raised together have been denied even [...]

— DAVID

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— DAVID

Taken a retired female Air Force veteran to question how she could ever lay her life on the line for a corrupt judicial system .

— SACHEL

The system destroys families creating trauma across multiple generations

— STEPHANIE

Shattered self and family. Human trafficking violations. Child abuse. The “justice” system is broken.

— TANYA

My family was destroyed by family court and Dr. Deborah O. Day. We were a loving family and I was their mom! My daughters were removed from my care in a hearing that the 5th District Court of Appeals said that Judge Shawn L. Briesse denied Mother's due process and the hearing to [...]

— LINDA MARIE

Empowered the abuser, punished the abused.

— MELISSA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This system has allowed an abusive addict to destroy my children and my family and has allowed a former attorney without a bar card for drugs to have unfettered access to addict my children to drugs..

— STACI

They illegally stole my 5 children off lies and expedited TPR. They are keeping them in foster care when there is a relative who has passed a home study to take them. They are keeping them for profit rather than placing them with family.

— MARISSA

You took our children, so all we had was whole lot of time and pissed off. You had money, I had the truth, and it set my children free.

— CRYSTAL

Destroyed my relationship with my children to the point my daughter states to DCF/Police “I love snuggling with daddy, but daddy is a bad man, he is mean to my mommy”...

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has caused so much division and destruction and grief in mine and my children’s lives... I spoke up for myself and them and they failed to protect us

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Irreparable damage to my professional reputation and my child’s reputation.

— KRISTIN

The State of Florida has weaponized the dependency system to turn my children into federal revenue streams, using fabricated evidence to kidnap them and judicial misconduct to hold them hostage, effectively trafficking them through foster care to harvest Title IV-E bounties.

— PAUL

Violated and dismantled us. With no empathy, no regard for my children and their futures and no sense of morality, family court and DCF continue their heinous tirades on us and we are tired.

— AMY

The system destroyed my family for years almost causing me to take my own life. After over 5 years and finally being reunified they have caused serious emotional damage to the relationship between my children and I as well as the sibling bonds from being separated for so long.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They have completely destroyed my grandkids, my husband, and myself. All over a lie that was proven to be a lie and still three kids weren't returned to us. There's also lies that have been given to my niece whom has the kids in paperwork. Blaten disgusting lies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Irreplaceable damages Motherhood, Childhood

— MELISSA

The broken system has only shown me how much we can't trust anyone. Which is sad because those are the people who promised to uphold the law and they are far from it. My heart breaks every day. I can't sleep, I cry randomly, I can't put on any weight and keep it, I feel [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Litigation abuse, torn my family apart, put my son in an extremely toxic environment !

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Trying make parents separate and division between extended family. Mother and son etc

— ANGELLA

They have stole my entire world made my life unmanageable my babies need me they want me

— HEARTHER

Lack of timely hearings, denial of time to properly hear final trial, allowed false testimony to be admitted into final order.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Caused endless problems, depression, kept putting us in prison and jail

— BRENDA

Destroyed my family.

— ALMA

It has made me completely irrelevant and my children have a constant feeling of being lost. Without a mother's love and guidance it's hard to be loved.

— MONA

Broke me mentally emotionally, and financially also destroyed my three boys relationship with their mother and their outlook on what a happy healthy family should be.

— SHELLEY

74 Florida parents submitted ranked quotes. 46 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/fl.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Florida report comes from Florida respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Florida — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 115 Florida families reporting here are not the universe of Florida families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics (email + name + submission date) are applied before aggregation. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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